After the Moscow summit, I saw Gorbachev one more time while I was president.

In December 1988—less than six weeks before Nancy and I were to leave the White House—he came to New York to make a speech to the United Nations at which he announced substantial cuts in the conventional forces of the Warsaw Pact.

Since I had last seen him, there had been more signs of change in the Soviet Union and its disintegrating empire: What had started as a trickle of refuseniks allowed to leave the Soviet Union was becoming a stream; the relentless Soviet expansionism in the Third World seemed to be waning; Cuba, under a U.S.-mediated settlement and apparently under pressure from Moscow, had agreed to remove its troops from Angola; Vietnam would soon begin pulling its forces from Cambodia; Moscow was no longer bankrolling the insatiable appetite of Syria's Hafez Assad for Soviet arms and had stopped jamming the broadcasts of Radio Liberty and Radio Free Europe.

When Gorbachev came to New York, I was concerned for his safety.

Soviet officials had expressed concern that if he visited the United States there might be an attempt on his life from the streets of New York.

Before we could respond and say Gorbachev was looked on favorably by most Americans and we didn't think he faced a danger in our country, we were told their concern was based not on fears that an American would try to assassinate him, but that while he was out of the Soviet Union there would be a coup attempt in Moscow—and as part of it, someone from the Eastern bloc would try to kill him and make it look as if an American had done it. I do not know to what extent the Soviet concern was warranted, but it didn't take a great deal of logic to imagine that Gorbachev had enemies in the Communist world. Our security people